UNESCO World Heritage Sites in India

Introduction to World Heritage Sites

A UNESCO World Heritage Site is a place of outstanding cultural or natural importance that has been listed by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) as belonging to the heritage of all humanity and as deserving international protection. The idea comes from the Convention Concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage, adopted by UNESCO in 1972. A site is inscribed on the World Heritage List by the World Heritage Committee if it has "Outstanding Universal Value" and meets at least one of ten selection criteria: six are cultural (criteria i to vi) and four are natural (criteria vii to x). Today more than 1,200 sites in over 160 countries are on the list. Being a World Heritage Site brings global recognition, funds for conservation, tourism and a duty on the country to protect the site. World Heritage Day is observed on 18 April.

How Many UNESCO Sites Does India Have?

India has 44 UNESCO World Heritage Sites as of 2025, after the Maratha Military Landscapes of India were inscribed in July 2025 as the 44th site. These comprise 36 cultural sites, 7 natural sites and 1 mixed site, which is Khangchendzonga National Park in Sikkim. India has one of the largest numbers of World Heritage Sites in the world, among the top six countries, behind Italy, China, Germany and France. The numbers can rise whenever new sites are added each year, so the latest count should always be checked on the UNESCO website. India hosted the 46th session of the World Heritage Committee in New Delhi in July 2024, the first time India hosted the meeting, and the Moidams of the Ahom dynasty in Assam were inscribed as India's 43rd site during that session. The first Indian sites were inscribed in 1983: the Ajanta Caves, the Ellora Caves, Agra Fort and the Taj Mahal.

Cultural and Natural Sites: What Is the Difference?

Cultural sites are places created by humans that have outstanding historical, artistic, architectural, archaeological or cultural value, such as monuments, buildings, temples, forts, ancient cities, cultural landscapes and railways. Examples in India include the Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Qutub Minar, Konark Sun Temple, Hampi, Khajuraho and the Rani ki Vav stepwell. Natural sites are areas of exceptional natural beauty or scientific importance, such as unique geological features, ecosystems, habitats of endangered species and outstanding biodiversity; Indian examples include Kaziranga National Park, Keoladeo National Park, Manas Wildlife Sanctuary, the Sundarbans, Nanda Devi and Valley of Flowers National Parks, the Great Himalayan National Park, and the Western Ghats. Mixed sites meet both cultural and natural criteria, and in India this is only Khangchendzonga National Park, listed in 2016. In short, cultural sites are made by people and celebrate human creativity, while natural sites are shaped by nature and celebrate natural wonders.

Three UNESCO Sites in Tamil Nadu

Three UNESCO World Heritage Sites in Tamil Nadu are the Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram, the Great Living Chola Temples and the Nilgiri Mountain Railway. The Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram, built by the Pallava dynasty in the 7th and 8th centuries, with its Shore Temple, Pancha Rathas and Arjuna's Penance, was inscribed in 1984. The Great Living Chola Temples were inscribed in 1987 with the Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur, and extended in 2004 to include the Brihadisvara Temple at Gangaikondacholapuram and the Airavatesvara Temple at Darasuram; they are called "living" because worship still continues. The Nilgiri Mountain Railway, a narrow metre-gauge rack-and-pinion railway running from Mettupalayam to Udhagamandalam (Ooty), was added in 2005 to the Mountain Railways of India, which also include the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway and the Kalka-Shimla Railway. In addition, a part of the Western Ghats, a natural site inscribed in 2012, lies in Tamil Nadu. Tamil Nadu thus has several cultural properties and a share in one natural property.

Other Notable Indian Sites

Other cultural sites include the Ajanta and Ellora Caves in Maharashtra, Fatehpur Sikri, Sanchi's Buddhist monuments, the Mahabodhi Temple at Bodh Gaya, the Churches and Convents of Goa, the Pattadakal group, the Elephanta Caves, Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus in Mumbai, Humayun's Tomb, Jantar Mantar in Jaipur, the Hill Forts of Rajasthan, the Victorian and Art Deco ensemble of Mumbai, the historic city of Ahmedabad (India's first World Heritage City, 2017), the Jaipur city, the Architectural Work of Le Corbusier in Chandigarh, Nalanda Mahavihara (2016), Dholavira (2021), Ramappa Temple in Telangana (2021), Santiniketan (2023) and the Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas (2023). Natural sites also include the Nanda Devi National Park. Besides the World Heritage List, UNESCO has an Intangible Cultural Heritage list in which India's items include Vedic chanting, Ramlila, Kumbh Mela, Yoga, Kolkata's Durga Puja and the Garba of Gujarat.

Protection and Management

In India, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), founded in 1861, protects cultural heritage under the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958, while wildlife sites are protected under the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972. Sites face threats such as pollution, as with the yellowing of the Taj Mahal's marble, overcrowding by tourists, urban development, climate change, neglect and vandalism. UNESCO may list a site as "in danger" if it is at serious risk. Tamil Nadu's temples are managed largely by the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department, while the ASI protects the major monuments. Chennai's Fort St. George and the Government Museum are among the protected heritage buildings.

Tentative List and Future

India has a Tentative List of sites for future nominations, which includes places such as the Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple at Srirangam in Tamil Nadu. Nominating a site requires a detailed dossier on its history and its management plan. Tourism and heritage education help to protect these sites for future generations.

Quick Facts

- India has 44 UNESCO World Heritage Sites as of 2025: 36 cultural, 7 natural and 1 mixed.
- Three Tamil Nadu sites: Mahabalipuram monuments (1984), Great Living Chola Temples (1987, extended 2004) and the Nilgiri Mountain Railway (2005).
- Cultural sites are made by humans; natural sites are shaped by nature, such as Kaziranga and the Sundarbans.
- The first Indian sites were inscribed in 1983: Ajanta, Ellora, Agra Fort and the Taj Mahal.
- The Western Ghats were inscribed in 2012.